On 16 January 1959, India raised the issue of repeated infiltration by Chinese troops. It drew attention to a more recent detachment of Chinese troops that had crossed into the region on 27 September 1958 and later departed towards Tazung Dam in Burma. This was an important landmark in the fast deteriorating relations between India and China, for the Chinese had entered Indian territory in NEFA for the first time.

Nehru was repeatedly being outmanoeuvred by Mao and Communist China. Ever since 1954, the Indian government had been in a reactive role, responding to Chinese moves while keeping the situation hidden from the people of India. Even the news about the construction of the Chinese National Highway G219 through Aksai Chin was kept a closely guarded secret.

By the time General Rajendrasinhji handed over charge as the COAS (with the president becoming the commander in chief, the army chief was now known as the Chief of Army Staff) to General S. M. Shrinagesh in 1955, both the Himmatsinhji and Kulwant Singh reports had been in circulation for a while. The former's recommendations to push troops forward was acted on, while the second report was ignored. Given the prime minister's public stand on China, the Cabinet decided that no military preparation against it was necessary. This would become the cornerstone of India's national policy with regard to China. It was also the guideline for the government, the civil services, the experts, the press and the public.

On 7 May 1957, General Kodandera Subayya Thimayya, better known as 'Timmy' took charge of the Indian Army. Like General Cariappa before him, Thimayya too gave his frank assessment of the Indian Army's fighting capabilities to the government. He said: 'Whereas in the case of Pakistan I have considered the possibility of a total war, I am afraid I cannot do so in regard to China. I cannot even as a soldier envisage India taking on China in an open conflict on its own. China's present strength in manpower, equipment and aircraft exceeds our resources a hundred-fold with the full support of the USSR, and we could never hope to match China in the foreseeable future. It must be left to the politicians and diplomats to ensure our security.'

From Thimayya's statement it was obvious that at the time the Indian Army and the government were under the impression that in the event of a confrontation with India, China would have the full support of the Soviet Union. Thimayya also advocated that should the Chinese penetrate the